SITUATION OVERVIEW



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Juana, 34, checks her drought-hit maize crop in La Lagunilla, Jalapa, Guatemala. CERF-funded anticipatory action is helping families detect and prevent acute malnutrition early. (19 August 2026)

El Niño is the warm phase of the El Niño–Southern Oscillation (ENSO) phenomenon, which in LAC typically brings drier and hotter conditions to Central America, the Caribbean and northern South America and heavy rainfall to the Pacific coast of South America. NOAA declared El Niño conditions on 11 June 2026, and the World Meteorological Organization (WMO) gives a probability of over 90 per cent that they will persist into early 2027, with strong or very strong intensity between November 2026 and January 2027, comparable to the events of 1982–83, 1997–98 and 2015–16.[9] Historical analysis of these episodes confirms protracted drought in the Dry Corridor and the Caribbean and severe flooding on the Pacific coasts, with lasting consequences for food security, nutrition and access to essential services, and this El Niño is unfolding in a context of record-high global temperatures, high fuel and fertiliser prices and constrained humanitarian financing.[10]

UNICEF's preliminary regional estimates indicate that 86 million people, including 25.8 million children, are exposed to El Niño-related hazards across Latin America and the Caribbean. Of these, up to 30 million people, including 9 million children, could face humanitarian needs, with an estimated 2.7 million children at heightened risk across 11 high-priority countries including Bolivia, Colombia, Cuba, Ecuador, El Salvador, Guatemala, Haiti, Honduras, Nicaragua, Peru and Venezuela. Impacts will not be confined to these countries, and priorities may shift as the conditions of the phenomenon evolves.[11]

Central America and Mexico – In the Dry Corridor, below-normal rainfall, an early and extended mid-season dry spell[12] and above-average temperatures have compromised the Primera, the first maize and bean harvest of the year, and put the Postrera, the second harvest starting in August, at risk. El Salvador recorded its driest August since 1971 and declared a nationwide red alert for drought on 25 August, while Honduras declared a national emergency on 19 August and placed 103 municipalities under red alert, with water rationing in Tegucigalpa.[13] In Guatemala, around 3 million people were already in Crisis or worse (IPC Phase 3+) at the start of the year. In Honduras, 1.8 million people, 18 per cent of the population, are projected in Phase 3+ through October.[14] A State of Emergency has been declared, while the humanitarian community has issued a Flash Appeal.[15] Panama also declared a national state of emergency on 25 August after flooding on its Caribbean coast. On the Pacific coast, Mexico has been hit by seven tropical systems, including the landfall of Tropical Storm Boris in June.

The Caribbean – Long-term drought established since late 2025 across the Eastern Caribbean, Jamaica and eastern Cuba is expected to deepen into the 2026–27 dry season, compounding Cuba's socio-economic crisis and Haiti's food crisis, while an intense heat season peaks in August and September.[16] The Atlantic hurricane season is forecast below normal, though warm Caribbean waters keep the risk of rapid intensification high.

South America – Ecuador raised its El Niño alert to red nationwide, and Peru declared a state of emergency in 22 of 24 regions ahead of a coastal flood season expected between November 2026 and April 2027. Colombia, Venezuela and Bolivia face falling reservoirs, water and power rationing and elevated wildfire risk, and in the Amazon basin, drought is expected to lower river levels and cut off riverine and Indigenous communities across northern Brazil, Bolivia, Peru and southern Venezuela, where the Orinoco and Amazon basins also face a high risk of forest fires; the State of Amazonas declared a preventive climate and environmental emergency in June.[17] In the south of the continent, successive storms in Chile in July caused 13 deaths and destroyed or severely damaged more than 3,400 homes, while 16,196 people were directly affected.[18] And southern Brazil, Argentina, Uruguay and Paraguay are preparing for above-normal rainfall and flooding in the La Plata Basin.

Several contextual factors compound these hazards and are being factored into UNICEF's preparedness and response. Electoral processes in Ecuador and recent changes of government in Colombia, Bolivia and Peru coincide with the period of greatest impact and will require additional attention to ensure continuity in preparedness planning, coordination and local emergency functions. Not all governments are expected to request international assistance, so UNICEF is planning its support accordingly. Insecurity in some coastal and border areas, fuel shortages and transport disruptions may constrain access and raise supply costs. In Panama, despite flooding on the Caribbean coast, low water levels in the canal watershed have already led the authorities to reduce daily transits, with further cuts possible if the drought deepens.[19] Meanwhile, reduced OCHA presence in several countries places a greater coordination burden on UNICEF and its partners.

FUNDING OVERVIEW AND PARTNERSHIPS

El Niño requirements are being consolidated under UNICEF's 2026 Humanitarian Action for Children (HAC) appeal for the LAC region, which requests US$53.8 million for disaster preparedness, Anticipatory Action and emergency response and was 45 per cent funded as of 30 June 2026.[20]

Funding is uneven across the region. In the Central American Dry Corridor, anticipatory financing is in place: the region's first collective anticipatory drought plan, facilitated by OCHA with the Governments of Guatemala, Honduras and El Salvador, released US$10.5 million from the Central Emergency Response Fund (CERF) on the June rainfall forecast, with UNICEF implementing nutrition and WASH components in all three countries, and United States funding through the OCHA-managed pooled funds is also supporting drought response in Colombia, Guatemala, Honduras and El Salvador.[21] Education, however, is not currently covered by these OCHA funding mechanisms, leaving a critical gap in anticipatory financing to protect education continuity and prevent learning loss and children leaving school. Outside the Dry Corridor, very limited pre-arranged financing is available for the South America and the Caribbean countries, while UNICEF COs are preparing for El Niño scenarios with core resources alone against requirements that are already substantial.[22]

UNICEF is mobilising additional resources to support preparedness and Anticipatory Action ahead of the expected peak of impacts: a